

MEZOLIT

SONGS FROM THE DANUBE BEND

The will-o-wisp flittered and flickered over the scrawny bushes of the midnight marshland as if searching for something. Shadows fled from it, regrouping just outside the circle of light, further deepening the gloom of the moonless night. For once the small group of figures crouched behind a nearby rock was glad for the darkness. Sweaty hands gripped stone maces harder, hearts were pounding loud with the fear that their own beating was going to give their owners' hiding place away.

The shining ball suddenly stopped above what first looked like a log bobbing gently on the water. A gasp from behind the rock and then a barely audible whisper: "Look, that's poor Hagon..." The ball lowered slowly, casting ever brighter light on what they could all now see was the body of a drowned man. The will-o-wisp hung still in the air for a moment, almost touching the back of its head, and that's when the first spear whizzed through the air.

The rest happened very quickly: the ball of light slammed down and fused into its prey and what used to be the body of Hagon was now the body of something else altogether. With a groan it rose from the water, its bloated and shimmering frame silhouetted against the dark sky it turned its head towards the rock, from behind which a woman and a man leapt forward, stone maces raised above their heads. At the same time a man's voice broke into a chant, first quiet then growing louder and finally splitting into two: a low, resonant melody from the throat and a thin, fluting voice from the same mouth.

The leather-clad woman got to the cadaver animated by ghostlight first, her stone mace striking down in an angry arc, missing just by inches as Hagon ducked to the side with surprising agility for a drowned man, grabbing her right wrist as he did so. She let out a painful yelp, gasping for air as if she were given an unwanted share of the fate of the unfortunate Hagon. They tugged at each other momentarily, each trying to topple the other forward but neither succeeding. Nor did they see the

second stone mace burst into flames and catch the thing that possessed the late Hagon square in the jaw. Hagon roared in pain, or at least someone roared with it for the voice was clearly not human and the words it uttered were not human words. The Hagon-thing let go of the woman, trying to shield its face from the fire of the mace but to no avail: a second blow crashed through its raised arms and struck it in the chest. It toppled backwards with a loud splash and after that, silence.

A third human stepped forward from the rock, even in furs he was visibly more slender than his friends wearing thick leather trousers and shirts. He was unarmed unless we count the little drum in his hand as a weapon, like the truly wise do.

“Are you okay, Lemea?”, he asked the woman who was now bent double in a sputtering fit like someone who had just been pulled out of the water.

“Will...live”, she replied between two wheezing coughs.

“The bastard almost took her down”, the man with the stone mace said.

“I was fearing that might happen, it's why I mixed in a song of air for her in your song of fire”, replied the one with the drum.

“Right, let's go. We need to get out of this horrible place and bury Hagon before daybreak”, said Lemea, finally overcoming her urge to gulp air.

“And we need to warn the others about ghostlight being around in these bogs, you know how where there's one, there's many.”

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World

The game of **Mezolit** is set in a highly fictionalised version of the Carpathian Basin, in Central Europe, during the mesolithic age. This age is often characterised by what its people didn't have yet: agriculture, metals and writing.

And while all of that may be true to a certain extent, the problem with such statements is that they make us forget that they were humans pretty much exactly like us: striving to survive not just as individuals but as groups and ultimately as a species, and find their places in the world.

Most of all though, the world of **Mezolit** is not the same as the real-world mesolithic Carpathian Basin. *It's got magic for a start.*

All told, this world can't be anything but a fantasy, and like most fantasy worlds, it is a projection of the author's ideas about their own environment onto the canvas of history, joining the dots of solid evidence with lines of imagination.

In this setting the dots are few and the lines are many.

It is in this world where your adventures will be set, seeking out places, creatures, and things that few do – hopefully returning with tales of the yet unknown.

Material culture

After the end of the last ice age the area of the Carpathian Basin became a lot warmer and more densely forested, reindeers migrated north and so did some of the people. Those that stayed behind have adapted to the new landscape and the new lifestyle it required: roaming herds of bison and red deer are tracked and hunted but also fiercely protected from depletion. Wood for fires and as construction material has become plentiful and the search for better materials and designs for tools is intensive.

Grasslands and carrs provide fibres for rope braiding and net weaving, which together with boat making have enabled relatively sedentary riverside fishing communities to form.

There's no large-scale agriculture but in places where there's less pressure to be constantly on the move there's very deliberate management and selection of useful plants, maybe even some crossbreeding attempts.

The main method of food preservation is air or smoke drying, which requires a lot of skill, especially in areas where salt isn't available.

Metal smelting has not yet been invented but metals are known and used by a lucky few. Meteoric iron, native copper, silver and death silver (a mercury-silver alloy) can all be found in small quantities if one knows where to look. Techniques for working these materials are not well-known but are around, and people are always experimenting with new ways of turning them into decorative objects or even tools.

Society

Camps

Most people of **Mezolit** live in camps that practise a semi-nomadic hunting-herding lifestyle. A camp is thus not just a physical structure but a societal one: a group that moves together, linked to some degree by kinship. Of course there may be variations to this theme – some camps may be entirely nomadic while others may group around static resources: waters rich in fish, cave systems that provide ready-made shelter, a source of drinking water and easily quarriable rock.

The social structure of the camp can also vary, some will have long-term leaders, others will choose short-term leaders for different situations but the main focus is always on the survival of the group as a whole. For this reason resolving inter-group conflicts with deadly warfare is very rare, if other methods fail, non-lethal fighting (better known as a brawl), duels or other forms of competition are preferred as a last resort.

Knowledge

Knowledge is hugely important to the people of **Mezolit**, probably far more important than in later ages. After all, both your own and your camp's survival may depend on it. And with no way to write things down (apart from drawings and some notch-based counting) all that knowledge has to be memorised and continuously re-expressed as rhymes, songs and poems.

Curiosity, wanderlust and ingenuity are thus seen as valuable traits, albeit slightly dangerous when in excess. Sure, it's good to discover new places and things but failure can easily be fatal. This is why the people blessed (or cursed) with too much curiosity will often become adventurers, roaming the land in small bands, chasing monsters of the stories of old, in search for rare resources or just travelling around to see what's over the next big hill. They are also spreaders of culture, often spending time with other camps, exchanging knowledge, solving problems for them to gain their trust. And although most are happy to see them arrive, they're equally anxious to move them on should they stay too long.

The collective knowledge of a camp can vary wildly but it could include observations about the position and movement of stars, weather patterns, the behaviour of animals and plants, and where to find useful resources, like flint or other types of rock.

Rituals and Art

Rituals, while their details can be highly abstract and artistic, are very closely tied to the rhythm of everyday life. Art is thus treated not so much as the expression of the self but as a way to control the world around you. And as songs or drawings can fill the world with real, tangible magic, this view is not unjustified.

Each camp may have their own particular twist on every ritual but the occasions calling for them are fairly universal: birth, reaching adulthood, death, the changing of the seasons, going on a journey, the completion of a journey, welcoming visitors, etc.

Environment

Climate

As has been mentioned above, the climate is continental with four seasons: warm/hot summers and freezing winters being separated by the changeable weather of spring and autumn seasons. Upland areas are densely forested while lower down we find rich grasslands and often marshes, especially in the vicinity of wide, meandering rivers. This allows for a variety of lifestyles but winter survival is often the hardest test for any community.

Fauna

The megafauna that dominated during the ice age are in retreat, woolly mammoths no longer roam these lands (they still roam elsewhere just not here) but cave lions do, with the occasional leopard and hyena hanging on.

Auroch, wild horses and deer are common, as are bears and wolves with whom people are competing for prey and habitat.

Neanderthals are no longer around but their legacy can be found both in some lineages of people, and in the objects they left behind. These (and other strange artefacts adventurers sometimes bump into) hint at a deep past that captures the imagination of many an inhabitant of **Mezolit**.

There are also a few dogs to be found, they arrived from the northeast with groups of nomadic hunters who roam the lands looking for richer hunting grounds.

The Supernatural

Although the people of **Mezolit** would never count them as different from "natural" creatures, beings we would consider magical are very much present in their environment.

Dragons, will-o-wisps, undead, talking trees, fey, spirits, and all kinds of creatures exist often on the periphery of the sphere humans occupy. Some are friendly, others less so, some are part of everyday life, others are obscure and few have even heard about them.

Lastly, far to the southeast, in a place we now call the *Fertile Crescent*, new types of beings have started to stir: **gods**. And while they're still a long way away from **Mezolit**, they've already begun their inexorable conquest across the lands, to eventually spell an end to the age of magic and turn all other supernatural creatures into a distant ancestral memory in people's imagination.

Time

Keen observers of nature, the people of **Mezolit** are well aware of its cycles: days, the phases of the moon, seasons and years are commonly used as points of reference when talking about time. Other references to time also exist, relating to the lifecycles of animals, plants and fungi, but these may not be as universally recognised.

The Land of Whispering Shadows

The Land of Whispering Shadows is the ever-shifting domain between life and death that everyone has to pass through at the end of their lives. But not every journey through it is one way. It is still possible to turn around and go back to life from here but it isn't easy and should you succeed, you may find the life you return to isn't exactly like the one you had left. Some even seek out this shadowy realm on purpose because of this – a dangerous practice that nevertheless has the potential to greatly enhance one's powers.

The most likely way for characters to find themselves in this strange in-between realm is through too many injuries sustained during their adventures. Should they wish to continue to live, they must find a way to resist the persistent pull of death towards the end of their path, turn around and fight whatever they have to face on the way back.

Characters

Characters in **Mezolit** can be described by four things: **who they are**, **what they can do**, **what they know** and **what they own**.

Of those, **who they are** is the simplest in terms of gameplay. Player characters can be as varied as any people, they only share one crucial characteristic: their inability to live without adventure. This makes others look at them with a mixture of slight suspicion and awe: their presence often spells danger but it is also accepted that knowledge, stories and artefacts they bring home from their travels may one day make the difference between survival and extinction. Adventurers who travel together are often from different camps but there's no hard rule about this. Beyond the basics players can choose their characters to be whoever they want to be.

What they can do is represented by *Attributes*, of which there are six. The starting values for them are determined at the start of the game and will change over the course of their adventure. They usually grow with experience and use but may go down temporarily as a result of wounds or other hindrances.

What they know is represented by the list of songs they can sing, tattoos they can draw and objects they can make. Songs are knowledge in its purest form: knowledge of the past, faraway lands, predicting the weather or the movement of the stars, and of ways to bend the world to one's will. Tattoos are a form of enchantment that can be

placed on an object or living being. And objects are, well, objects: tools, weapons, musical instruments, anything. Each player character will start with a selection of these from the knowledge their group has at the start of the character's adventures. Later on they will learn new things and with experimentation maybe even invent new objects, songs or tattoos of their own.

What they own is the list of items they carry and the tattoos or drawings on their body. It's worth noting that while the abstract concept of “property” may not exist in this world, personal ownership of items and thus the idea of “theft” are widely recognised.

Attributes

A character's attributes represent the extent and limits of their capabilities. It is these attributes that are tested every time a player has to roll to see whether the action they planned for their character succeeds or fails.

Each one has a maximum and a current value between 1 and 10. Some effects (most notably wounds sustained in combat) may reduce the current value of an attribute, this can be restored with resting, healing or magic, but never beyond the maximum value. During the character's adventures the maximum value of an attribute may rise but never beyond 10.

Attributes have a primary purpose and any number of secondary purposes. The only difference between them is that the primary purpose is covered in the rules that follow while for secondary purposes the storyteller has to judge which attribute applies for a given situation and how the roll should be made.

Hunting

The primary purpose of this attribute is combat, both in attacking and defending. Its secondary uses include tracking prey, feats of strength or agility, or reading the signs of a fight that had taken place in the past.

Making

The primary purpose of this attribute is making objects, be they tools, clothes, weapons, tattoos or talismans. Secondary uses include challenges requiring manual dexterity and patience.

Life

This attribute shows how well a character can tolerate wounds, diseases and poisons. These can decrease it and if it reaches 0, the character loses consciousness and enters *The Land of Whispering Shadows*. Its secondary uses include dealing with exhaustion and other feats of endurance.

Cunning

This attribute shows how well a character can deceive others or detect if they're being deceived. This can be verbal deception (i.e. lying), skulking in shadows, camouflaging people or objects, distract opponents, etc. Its secondary uses include challenges that require quick, creative thinking.

Song

This attribute shows the power of a character's songs. Songs are key to culture, civilisation and ultimately, group survival. In the world of **Mezolit** magic is alive and songs are the main conduits for it. But in the absence of a writing system, as a secondary use, songs are also the vehicle for remembering and passing on knowledge of the natural world, history and even technology.

Anima

This attribute shows the character's spiritual force. It shows how well they can resist magic and their ability to imbue items with magical power. Its secondary uses include challenges that require willpower, interacting with the spirits of the world, or displays of dominance.

Gameplay

The game is ideally played by 4-6 people, one of whom is the **storyteller** and the others the **players**. The storyteller's role is to bring the world of **Mezolit** to life, populate it with ordinary and wondrous creatures, places and events, while each of the players assume the role of a character in the story, driving it in various directions.

Creating a character

Creating a character is a relatively simple process in this game.

First of all the player and the storyteller together will decide what kind of *camp background* the character has. This determines the character's starting knowledge and equipment, although if the storyteller allows for it, this can be diverged from.

Then the player names the character and decides their character's age, looks and personality. Of course all of these can change later during the game, usually as a result of the passage of time and their experiences.

Finally the player needs to distribute 18 points between their character's 6 *Attributes*, with each attribute needing at least 1 and at most 5 points. (*Note: attributes can of course rise beyond 5 later on, this is just a starting restriction*). They will then add the modifiers coming from their chosen *camp background* to these attributes, so in total their attributes should add up to 22 points.

Dice

When the players want their character to attempt an action whose outcome is *uncertain*, the storyteller can ask them to roll the dice. The exact details of the roll are always up to the storyteller but the basic mechanics of every roll is always the same.

Rolling

In the game of **Mezolit** there is only one kind of dice roll: roll a number of 6-sided dice, treat every roll of 1-4 as no success, a 5 as one success and a 6 as two successes, then add up all the successes obtained from the dice. This can be written as <x>D where <x> is the number of dice rolled.

So for example 4D means: roll with 4 dice and count all 5s rolled as 1 success, and each 6 rolled as 2 successes.

The number of dice rolled usually equals the attribute that is being used for the action (i.e. *Hunting* for attacking with a weapon, *Cunning* for trying to distract an enemy, *Song* for trying to recall knowledge, etc.) Tools, amulets, magic effects or others helping with the action can also add (or occasionally subtract) dice.

Determining success or failure

In an uncontested roll the total number of successes directly determines the outcome of an action: for simple/easy tasks 1 success is enough, for more complicated tasks 2 successes are required, harder tasks still can require 3 or even more successes to perform. If the total number of successes surpasses this threshold by 2 or more, the action can be deemed as a resounding success. What this means in practice depends on the action itself and is determined by the storyteller. Similarly if the total successes rolled are 2 or more under the threshold, it counts as a resounding failure. Again the exact details of this are determined by the storyteller but as a general rule it should not lead to the death or injury of the character, rather it should be something that moves the story on in an unexpected or unplanned direction.

Contested dice rolls work in a very similar way with the exception that the threshold is determined by the total successes rolled by the opponent. In case of a tie in a contested dice roll the situation remains unchanged.

Helping

Helping others is fundamental in this game: one person standing against a cave bear has no chance but four of them acting as a unit do, even if only one of them is fighting it directly. Similarly, multiple people chanting the same magical song as a choir will have a stronger effect than just someone doing it on their own.

For direct help the helper must first choose how they want to help the helpee, for example someone may try to distract the cave bear while the other one attacks. Then they should roll according to the nature of the action (i.e. *Cunning* for distraction or camouflage, *Hunting* for trying to raise a shield for someone else being attacked) and the number of successes they roll is then added to the number of dice the helpee can roll.

For example let's look at this scenario: **Player A** tries to distract a bear who's attacking **Player B**. **Player A** has a *Cunning* score of 4, so they roll **4D**. The result is 3,6,1 and 4, which means they rolled 2 successes. When the bear attacks **Player B**, they can thus use 2 extra dice in their *Hunting* roll to defend themselves.

It is also possible to offer indirect help by performing a separate action (for example singing a magical song or knocking an opponent over), in these cases the number of helping dice is determined by the song strength or the number of extra successes in a contested or uncontested roll.

Combat

In a dangerous world sometimes the characters will find themselves fighting for their lives. These are the rules for those occasions.

Timing and actions

Unlike in most games, combat is not divided into rounds. Instead at the start of an encounter the players can discuss what their characters are planning to do and can freely coordinate their actions afterwards too. Their characters can talk to each other and use this to their advantage. (Of course if they want to stay silent for an ambush, this avenue is closed to them but they can still probably use hand signals or non-verbal sounds to cue each other's pre-agreed actions.)

Attacking

When a character is attacking, they start by rolling a *Hunting* roll, modified by their weapon of choice plus any magic or help that is applicable. The number of successes they roll is their attacking total.

Defending

Next the target of the attack rolls a *Hunting* roll, their number of successes is the defending total. If the defending total reaches or exceeds the attacking total, they've managed to avoid or parry the attack.

Wounding

If the attacking total is higher, we subtract the defending total from it, this gives the wounding total.

Finally the target has to roll a *Life* roll to see how much they can resist the damage done by the attack. Any successes they roll here are subtracted from the wounding total, and if the remaining wounding is still greater than zero, that number is subtracted from the target's *Life*. (Note: this also means that next time they're wounded, they'll have less chance to resist damage.)

Healing

Wounds sustained in the game will heal slowly and naturally with time but it's a lot faster if wounds are properly tended to. In terms of game mechanics this means that once a day the wounded character can make a recovery roll: this is a *Life* roll and the character can recover as many *Life* points lost as the successes they rolled. (Note: obviously the roll always has to be made with the current and not maximum *Life*. Serious injuries are extra hard to recover from.)

Tending the wounds adds extra dice to this roll. The three main ways of helping are various wound dressings, tattoos and healing songs, but other creative methods can also add the odd extra die. (For example constructing a stretcher that allows the wounded person to rest while the party is on the move.)

On the brink of death

Whenever a character's *Life* reaches 0, they enter the *Land of Whispering Shadows*, a weird liminal world between life and whatever comes after it.

With their material body left behind, their shape and characteristics in this world are determined by their personality: their *Cunning* attribute will temporarily replace their *Hunting* attribute, their *Song* attribute becomes their *Making* attribute and their *Life* (which is now 0) is replaced by their *Anima*.

The world surrounding them closely resembles that which they've left behind but the lights will have changed and space itself warps in ways that are difficult to figure out. Distances are not what they seem and what appears like a straight line might feel like climbing a mountain.

This makes finding their way back to their body quite challenging. The exact options available is up to the storyteller, they could cajole a passing spirit into acting as a guide, figure out the exact geometry of their surroundings or just make a beeline towards their body by sheer force of will, but from the perspective of the game's rules avoiding death requires a *Cunning*, *Song* or *Anima* roll, modified by items or tattoos they might be wearing, or the *Song of Calling* being sung.

The difficulty of this roll is 1 at the first attempt and increases by 1 on every subsequent attempt, regardless of whether the previous attempt has succeeded or failed. Thus a character finding themselves in this shadowy realm too often will eventually find it impossible to return.

Items

In this game all items are temporary and things like weapons, advanced tools or magic items can wear out by use. (Basic tools and clothes do too but repairing or replacing them is implied to happen throughout a normal day so in terms of game mechanics they count as permanent.)

Items' basic function is to give extra dice to certain rolls, a weapon will add to *Hunting* rolls, a suitably prepared wolf pelt will add to *Cunning* rolls for camouflage and so on.

Such items have two characteristics: item strength determines how many dice can be added to rolls, and item charge determines how many times an item can be used before they wear out or break.

Making items

Mundane items

Making mundane items requires the character to have the knowledge of making that item. They also need to have the right tools and materials, and once they have all this, they can roll a *Making* roll. The difficulty of the roll depends on the item: knapping a flint arrowhead is an easy task, making an unfired clay pot is one category harder, and making a glazed pot that is fired too is a hard task.

If the character is familiar with the item they try to make but not with how to make it, the roll is one category harder than it normally would be.

On a resounding success the item either becomes unusually strong and durable (extra item strength & charges) or acquires new and unexpected properties. For example a woven basket may become an effective defensive weapon this way. This is in fact the most common way of inventing new items.

Magic items

Making magic items is a much more involved process, requiring three steps. The steps can be performed by different characters and they are:

1. First the item itself needs to be crafted, this determines the amount of magic the item can hold. The crafter has to roll a *Making* roll, and the number of successes will be the maximum item strength and charge the item can accommodate.
2. In the second step a song needs to be sung, determining the magical effect and the successes rolled on a *Song* roll will determine the strength of the effect. If this would exceed the item's maximum strength, the item strength will be equal to its maximum strength instead.
3. Lastly the number of successes on an *Anima* roll determines the charges of the item. Similarly to the second step, should this be higher than the maximum item charge, it will be set to that instead.

Tattoos

Tattoos resemble magic items but they work in a very different way. (Some of them can be painted on objects or carved into trees but for the sake of simplicity we'll call them tattoos too as they work in exactly the same way.)

To create a tattoo, the tattooist has to make a successful *Making* roll against the tattoo's making difficulty. If the tattoo is put on a living being, it belongs to that being from then on. If it's on a non-living object, it belongs to its maker. All told, a person can have as many tattoos belonging to them as their *Anima* attribute.

The strength and the number of charges of a tattoo is fixed, although it is possible to develop improved versions of a drawing (by rolling a resounding success when making them for example). Some tattoos provide a constant effect and thus have no charges but even those that have to be activated recharge by next sunrise. This makes them very powerful compared to other items but really powerful tattoos are hard to come by and make.

Repairing items

While all items deteriorate with use, as a general rule characters try to keep them in good shape. This means that in the absence of time pressure or other extreme circumstances repairable items are kept at maximum charge as part of normal resting activities.

Even under time pressure, mundane items can simply be repaired by a *Making* roll. Given the right tools and materials repairing an item counts as an easy task, which means that 1 success will restore an item charge, while 3 successes will restore all of the item's charges.

Restoring charges of a magic item works in a similar way except the roll required is *Anima*.

Tattoos cannot be restored. (They can of course still be redrawn by following the process of creating a new tattoo.)

Magic

For the people of **Mezolit**, magic is part of everyday life in a way our modern brains find difficult to comprehend. While we tend to think in neatly delineated spells, the magic of **Mezolit** is in the songs and rhythms of nature. Singing a song about the past is magic: it creates a very real connection to people who are dead. Knowing the migration patterns of animals is magic too, and so is seeing the figure of a small sculpture you're about to carve out of a deer antler.

Of course in terms of game mechanics the magic we're going to talk about is only that which tries to directly affect the flow of the world, but it's important to remember that this distinction is ours, not theirs.

In any case, a magical song is just like any other song and to sing it you need to roll an uncontested *Song* roll against the difficulty of the song. The song's strength is the number of successes above the threshold. (*Note: a song that thus ends up with a strength of 0 still takes effect*) If the song affects unwilling targets, they can contest this by rolling *Anima* to see if they can reduce the song's strength. If the strength goes below zero, the song will not affect them (but it may still affect other targets).

The effect of the song lasts while you're singing the song. (Of course it may have longer lasting aftereffects, i.e. a flammable object lit on fire with song will keep on burning.)

Normally you can only sing one song at the time but you can attempt to weave multiple songs together by throat singing or overtone singing. In these cases you need to add their difficulties together and roll against that target. If the roll succeeds, both songs will take effect, if it fails, they both fail.

Learning

Characters start out with an ability to make the items they own and the tattoo they have, as listed for their *camp*. During the game however they can acquire new knowledge either from each other or from the people and creatures they meet.

Learning is hard, which is reflected by the fact that when a character tries to make an item or tattoo for the first time, the difficulty counts as double for them, i.e. if an item has a difficulty of *Easy*, they need to roll 2 successes instead of 1, 4 for *Medium* and 6 for *Hard*.

Of course they can get help with this, which can take one of two forms: they can follow someone who already knows how to make the item or tattoo, who is *guiding* the character through the process: the number of successes of the teacher's *Making* roll can be used as extra dice on the student's attempt to replicate the effort.

The other way of helping is by the teacher singing a *Song*, *explaining* all the tricks and techniques to use, again the number of successes on the teacher's roll add extra dice to the student's initial *Making* attempt.

Learning a new song is very similar to the above, with the only difference being that help can only be given through *guiding*, which requires the student to sing along with the teacher rather than using their *Making* attribute.

Camp backgrounds

River fishing camp

These camps follow a cycle of settlement and upheaval on the steeper riverbanks, staying in one place for several years, until some local resource (wood, reeds, etc.) gets close to depletion, then move to a different stretch of the river.

Their diet is probably the most varied and healthy of all the people, at least until the rivers freeze over in the winter.

The main activities beyond fishing are rope and netmaking and boat building. The two main types of boat are the log canoe style (a long and slender boat made via hollowing out a tree log) and the coracle style (animal skin stretched over a wooden framework)

Their clothing is a mixture of woven plant fibres and fish skin, while they preserve food mainly by sun or wind drying.

Attributes	Items	Songs	Tattoos
<i>Making: +1</i> <i>Life: +2</i> <i>Cunning: +1</i>	<i>Rope</i> <i>Stone hand axe</i> <i>Wooden spear</i> <i>Flint and firestone</i> <i>Net</i> <i>Woven basket</i>	<i>Song of Air</i> <i>Song of Stunning</i> <i>Song of the Ghost Light</i> <i>Song of the Waves</i>	<i>The Slippery Eel</i>

Forest hunter-gatherer camp

These camps rely on the wide variety of resources offered by the deciduous forests that took over mountainous and hilly regions after the withdrawal of the ice sheets. Typically they spend summers in forest shelters, collecting supplies for the winter, when they withdraw into caves to survive the snow and the cold.

They're roamers of forests, know all the plants and mushrooms that grow there and excellent at finding their way. They're also opportunistic hunters of big game, which is their main source of clothing material and provides huge amounts of meat that is smoked for preservation.

Attributes	Items	Songs	Tattoos
<i>Hunting: +1</i> <i>Song: +1</i> <i>Anima: +2</i>	<i>Antler staff</i> <i>Stone axe</i> <i>Wooden spear</i> <i>Flint and firestone</i> <i>Tinder fungus</i> <i>Bone flute</i>	<i>Song of the North Star</i> <i>Song of the Ghost Light</i> <i>Song of the Wolf</i> <i>Song of the Bear</i>	<i>The Balancing Stag</i>

Stone quarry camp

These camps move around a lot throughout the year between various sources of stone in hilly regions, and riverside claypits for pottery work.

Their expertise with recognising, quarrying and working different types of stone or clay is unsurpassed, but it also means they're more reliant on trade with other camps for their food or clothing, which therefore often resembles that of the people living around them.

Attributes	Items	Songs	Tattoos
<i>Making: +2</i> <i>Cunning: +1</i> <i>Song: +1</i>	<i>Antler hammer</i> <i>Stone axe</i> <i>Stone-tipped spear</i> <i>Obsidian scraper</i> <i>Sling</i> <i>Shaped slingstone</i>	<i>Song of the Bat</i> <i>Song of Fire</i> <i>Song of the Ghost Light</i> <i>Song of the Stone</i>	<i>The Crafty Crow</i>

Herd follower camp

These camps are always on the move, accompanying herds of auroch or other herbivores across the Great Plains. They hunt the animals as a group but at the same time they are also careful to not harm the herd's health as a whole, being acutely aware that their entire existence relies on it.

They are the undisputed champions of leatherworking and makers of many bone tools and intricately carved objects of art. Since they're always on the move, they trade a lot with the camps they pass by.

On their journeys they also forage but only from easy sources: mushrooms and berries are easy to pick on the move, digging up roots is not.

Their clothing is almost completely animal-based: leather prepared in various ways, bone buckles and leather lacing are what you'll find them wearing the most.

Attributes	Items	Songs	Tattoos
<i>Hunting: +2</i> <i>Making: +1</i> <i>Life: +1</i>	<i>Bone flute</i> <i>Stone-tipped spear</i> <i>Woven basket</i> <i>Tinder fungus</i> <i>Stone hand axe</i> <i>Leather tent</i>	<i>Song of the North Star</i> <i>Song of Stunning</i> <i>Song of the Plains Wind</i> <i>Song of the Buzzard</i>	<i>The Bull Auroch</i>

Carr stilt house camp

These camps sprung up in the wooded floodplain wetlands and oxbow lakes of big rivers. A landscape dominated by alder and ash providing shade for a boggy, semi-submerged ground teeming with ferns, reeds and waterfowl, it's a rich source of food and building material.

Stilt house people are the only truly sedentary folk in **Mezolit** as most of their lives are spent close to their circular communal stilt houses framed with alderwood, with mud walls.

As food is difficult to preserve in this environment, their diet is highly seasonal: eggs in spring, waterfowl and other small game in summer and autumn, and fish in the winter. Their well-insulated houses are key to winter survival, as is the peat that fuels their fires.

Their clothes consist of artfully stitched together pelts of small mammals (usually otters), decorated with feathers and supplemented with textiles woven from reed fiber, which is also the source material for their ropes, which are said to be the best around.

Attributes	Items	Songs	Tattoos
<i>Hunting: +I</i> <i>Song: +2</i> <i>Anima: +I</i>	<i>Moss dressing</i> <i>Bow</i> <i>Woven basket</i> <i>Reed arrow</i> <i>Rope</i> <i>Hand drum</i>	<i>Song of the Ghost Light</i> <i>Song of Air</i> <i>Song of Bonding</i> <i>Song of the Snake</i>	<i>The Gentle Moss</i>

Salt mine trappers

These camps are based around the massive salt deposits in the Carpathian Mountains, which gave rise to a unique style of survival.

Mining salt in **Mezolit** is tricky but in the places where these camps originate salt comes all the way to the surface, allowing for open-cast quarrying, which happens in spring. The salt is then dissolved in shallow brine pools, these dry out during the summer and the crystals can be collected once temperatures start to drop.

Autumns are spent with trapping – cave bears, large predators but also deer and smaller mammals are plentiful, and their salted meat helps the camp overwinter, while their hide can also be preserved in salt.

Winters are particularly harsh here: fur-trimmed leather clothing on top of an inner layer sewn from tinder-fungus is worn to keep the cold out.

The next summer the salt and the preserved and prepared hides are loaded on log rafts that are navigated down mountain rivers to the plains where they are exchanged for things that would be hard to find in the mountains.

These "fairs" are held at the confluences of large rivers, where large wooden and sometimes stone structures have been built. Around midsummer's day the plains and mountain people get together for a large feast and exchange of goods.

The salt mine trappers then start their much longer and more exhausting journey back up the river with their haul, arriving just in time for the autumn hunting season...

Attributes	Items	Songs	Tattoos
<i>Life: +1</i> <i>Cunning: +2</i> <i>Anima: +1</i>	<i>Spear, flint-tipped</i> <i>Flint adze</i> <i>Rope</i> <i>Tinder fungus</i> <i>Stone mace</i> <i>Dressing, herbal</i>	<i>Song of Fire</i> <i>Song of the Second Moon</i> <i>Song of the Wolf</i> <i>Song of the Snowdrift</i>	<i>The Sneaky Lynx</i>

Tables

Items				
Name	Making difficulty	Item strength	Item charges	Description
Antler hammer	Easy(1)	1	20	An antler that can be used for mining, flint-knapping or at a push, to hit other creatures.
Antler staff	Medium(2)	2	5	A hooked antler of a red deer affixed to a long staff. Can be used for hooking branches, digging but also for attacking and defending.
Arrow, flint-tipped	Hard(3)	2	5	A complex arrow with a wooden shaft and a sharp flint tip, affixed using tar and sinew. <i>(Note: Arrows are made in bunches of 5)</i>

Name	Making difficulty	Item strength	Item charges	Description
Arrow, reed	Easy(1)	0	5	A light hunting arrow for small game. <i>(Note: Arrows are made in bunches of 5)</i>
Arrow, wooden	Medium(2)	1	5	An arrow made of a single piece of wood, with a sharpened tip. <i>(Note: Arrows are made in bunches of 5)</i>
Bone flute	Hard(3)	1	20	Can be used in conjunction with singing to improve <i>Song</i> rolls.
Bow	Hard(3)	2	10	Can only be used for attacking and needs an arrow.
Dressing, herbal	Medium(2)	1	1	A wound dressing, it can be made of many widely available healing herbs. Like all wound dressings, it must be made on the spot and it will add as many dice to the recovery roll of an injured person as the item's strength.

Name	Making difficulty	Item strength	Item charges	Description
Dressing, moss	Medium(2)	3	1	A very potent wound dressing, it requires rare sphagnum moss to make. Like all wound dressings, it must be made on the spot and it will add as many dice to the recovery roll of an injured person as the item's strength.
Dressing, puffball	Medium(2)	2	1	A fairly potent wound dressing, it requires spores of the giant puffball mushroom to make. Like all wound dressings, it must be made on the spot and it will add as many dice to the recovery roll of an injured person as the item's strength.
Flint adze	Hard(3)	3	10	Can be used for digging, woodworking and fighting.
Flint and firestone	Easy(1)	1	10	Fire lighting tools that improve rolls for <i>Song of Fire</i>

Name	Making difficulty	Item strength	Item charges	Description
Hand drum	Hard(3)	2	5	Can be used in conjunction with singing to improve <i>Song</i> rolls.
Leather tent	Hard(3)	-	-	Wooden poles and leather flaps that can be quickly assembled into a tent by a group of 2-3 people. The tent provides shelter from the elements for 4-6 people, making it easier to recover from wounds, make and repair items in bad weather.
Mushroom bowl	Medium(2)	1	5	Some mushrooms can be formed into a bowl shape and dried to create a usable vessel for liquids. Heated with hot stones it can be used to turn dried food into soup, which gives an extra die to a recovery roll.

Name	Making difficulty	Item strength	Item charges	Description
Net	Easy(1)	0	3	Can be cast for attacking but instead of wounding, it reduces the target's <i>Hunting</i> ability. It can be made from rope.
Obsidian scraper	Medium(2)	3	10	Can be used in the making of wooden or leather items.
Rope	Medium(2)	2	5	Gives bonus to checks for climbing. Can also be used to tie things together.
Sling	Hard(3)	1	20	Can launch a suitable pebble or stone to great distances. Can only be used for attacking.
Slingstone, shaped	Medium(2)	1	5	Although a sling will launch any stone of vaguely the right size, shaped stones can provide an advantage against their intended targets.

Name	Making difficulty	Item strength	Item charges	Description
Spear, flint-tipped	Medium(2)	3	2	
Spear, wooden	Easy(1)	2	4	Basically a sharpened stick which can only be used for attacking. It can also be thrown.
Stone axe	Medium(2)	2	5	A sharpened, flat stone mounted into a wooden haft. Can be used for attacking and defending.
Stone hand axe	Easy(1)	1	10	A teardrop-shaped stone that can be held in the palm and swung. Can only be used for attacking.
Stone mace	Medium(2)	3	5	A large, round stone set on top of a wooden stick. It can be used to whack or smash things, it isn't really suitable for defending.
Tinder fungus	Easy(1)	1	1	Dried tree fungus that improves rolls for <i>Song of Fire</i>

Name	Making difficulty	Item strength	Item charges	Description
Woven basket	Medium(2)	2	20	Can be used for carrying things or crab fishing.

Tattoos				
Name	Making difficulty	Item strength	Item charges	Description
The Balancing Stag	Hard(3)	2	3	Usually inscribed on the thigh or calf, this tattoo gives the wearer a supreme sense of balance, adding dice to any rolls relating to gaining or avoiding losing balance.
The Bull Auroch	Medium(2)	3	3	This chest tattoo helps the wearer when they are attempting a feat of strength or endurance.

Name	Making difficulty	Item strength	Item charges	Description
The Campfire	Medium(2)	2	1	The Campfire is usually tattooed above the heart, and is visible as a bright bonfire in <i>Land of Whispering Shadows</i> , aiding the character's soul in returning to its body. It adds the strength of the tattoo to the dice roll to return.
The Crafty Crow	Hard(3)	2	3	The wearer can activate this tattoo to add dice to their <i>Making</i> or <i>Cunning</i> roll.
The Gentle Moss	Hard(3)	1	3	This greenish tattoo resembles moss covering the skin. When activated, it grows to cover the entire body, providing an extra die to <i>Cunning</i> rolls to hide or <i>Life</i> rolls to resist <i>wounding</i> . It can do each of these once per activation.

Name	Making difficulty	Item strength	Item charges	Description
The Hand	Easy(1)	1	-	When a group of people make this tattoo together, they will become able to locate each other by concentrating for a short time. <i>Note: this tattoo is made by spraying paint (usually ochre) from the mouth over one's own hand stretched out against a cave wall.</i>
The Lizard Tail	Hard(3)	2	1	When activated, this tattoo instantly regenerates 2 lost <i>Life</i> points.
The Slippery Eel	Hard(3)	2	3	This tattoo can cover an entire arm, snaking around it multiple times. The wearer can activate it to add dice to their defensive rolls in combat.

Name	Making difficulty	Item strength	Item charges	Description
The Sneaky Lynx	Hard(3)	2	3	This tattoo is usually inked on the palm or the soles of the feet and looks like fur. When activated, it adds dice to the wearer's <i>Cunning</i> rolls when they try to hide or stalk.
The Watchful Eye	Medium(2)	1	-	An eye that can be inscribed on a number of objects. Any creature with <i>Anima</i> that enters the territory bounded by the inscribed objects triggers an alarm in the maker of this tattoo. The alarm feels like a sudden and distinct sense of unease that gets stronger the higher the intruder's <i>Anima</i> .

Songs		
Title	Difficulty	Description
Song of Air	Medium(2)	Allows you to breathe underwater or in other places with no breathable air. This song is a continuous murmur sung with a closed mouth and circular breathing.
Song of Bonding	Easy(1)	When two objects are pressed together, this song will create a bond between them. The strength of the bond depends on how well the objects fit each other: two parts of a broken stick or a torn rope are fused together perfectly, while a stone affixed to the end of the stick by this song alone will come off fairly easily. It does however add dice to any <i>Making</i> roll involving joining objects together.

Title	Difficulty	Description
Song of Calling	Medium(2)	Tries to call a stricken being back from the brink of death. The song's strength can be added to any roll made by the target in <i>The Land of the Whispering Shadows</i> . This song has a keening, otherworldly tone, which may cause people who hear it to burst into tears.
Song of Fire	Medium(2)	Lights a flammable object on fire. If targeted on a living creature, it causes wounding equal to the song's strength.
Song of Healing	Easy(1)	The target can add the strength of this soothing song to their recovery roll.
Song of Stunning	Hard(3)	Not so much a song but a sudden, ear-piercingly loud scream that stuns all creatures in front of you. It reduces their <i>Hunting</i> ability for a few moments by as many points as the song's strength.
Song of the Bat	Easy(1)	This song is sung in a pitch too high for human ears to hear, it allows you to “see” in the dark through echolocation.

Title	Difficulty	Description
Song of the Bear	Hard(3)	Gives you the commanding (or frightening) presence of the bear. Increases your <i>Anima</i> by the spell's strength. To the untrained ear or from a distance this song sounds like the roar of an angry bear, which may prompt sensible creatures to make a hasty exit.
Song of the Buzzard	Easy(1)	Evoking the plaintive, far-carrying call of the common buzzard allows the singer to see the surrounding area from a bird's eye view, seeing far and wide. (<i>Note: this song only works in daylight and outdoors, but is not blocked by clouds.</i>)
Song of the Ghost Light	Easy(1)	Summons a small globe of light mid-air which will provide light in darkness and can scare wild animals. You can move it around at walking pace.
Song of the North Star	Easy(1)	Gives you the location of the North Star in the sky, even in broad daylight, in a cave, or under cloudy skies. (<i>Note: Due to the precession of equinoxes the North Star is actually Vega, a star far brighter than our present pole star Polaris.</i>)

Title	Difficulty	Description
Song of the Plains Wind	Medium(2)	Summons the dry, hot summer winds of the Great Plain. The wind isn't strong but it is persistent and can carry with it tiny clay particles that can blind a creature.
Song of the Second Moon	Easy(1)	Covers the entire area in shimmering silvery light, similar to that of real moonlight. The light is faint and is only visible to those the singer chooses to see it.
Song of the Snake	Medium(2)	Enchants a rope to move, tangle and untangle at will. It can be used to topple a creature, or bound one of their limbs if they fail a <i>Cunning</i> roll against the spell's strength. Alternatively it can be used to calm down a snake and make it ignore you.
Song of the Snowdrift	Medium(2)	Summons a sudden drift of snowflakes that fly through the air in the chosen direction, bringing chilling cold and making anything involving movement, sight or balancing more difficult for those caught within.

Title	Difficulty	Description
Song of the Stone	Hard(3)	Enchants a piece of stone to be lighter, heavier, harder or softer. If used on stone tools or weapons, it increases the item's strength with the spell's strength.
Song of the Waves	Easy(1)	Calms waters, makes it easier to sail against the wind or currents.
Song of the Wolf	Medium(2)	This howl-like song allows you to send a simple message over a long distance. It travels even further at night, and if any wolves are hearing it, they will repeat it, allowing it to travel further yet. This song is almost indistinguishable from a wolf's howl, only people who you target will be able to decipher its meaning.

Name:
Background:
Age:

Description:

Hunting: max: _/□□□□□□□□□□
Making: max: _/□□□□□□□□□□
Life: max: _/□□□□□□□□□□
Cunning: max: _/□□□□□□□□□□
Song: max: _/□□□□□□□□□□
Anima: max: _/□□□□□□□□□□

Songs known

Song	Difficulty

Notes:

